would often involve the submission of grants for pious women fallen on hard times, the handing out of presents, promotions for men who had distinguished themselves with service and ‘possibly listening to political or military intelligence gathered through networks linked to his harem’.

The year 1580 also saw the arrival of the beleaguered Kashmir sultan, Yusuf Shah Chak, at the Mughal court. Akbar had already sent ambassadors to Kashmir, in 1570 and 1578, to gather information on the state of affairs in that kingdom and to also, not inconsequently, inform the nobility and residents of the glory and wealth of the Mughal Empire. The lesson had not been lost on Yusuf Shah Chak, long used to pragmatically accepting the symbolic sovereignty of powerful neighbours. He had shown allegiance by sending princesses as brides for Salim, by reciting the khutba, and striking coins in the name of the Mughal Padshah. Over time, these placatory gestures eroded the charisma of the sultan in his own country, encouraging dissidents and now, in desperation, he had come to the Mughal court for help. Akbar greeted him warmly, courteously offering him two mistresses, and Yusuf Shah Chak stayed at the court for almost a year. Eventually, Yusuf Shah Chak was dissuaded by his noblemen from accepting Mughal military help and he escaped back to Kashmir. The damage was done, however, for once Akbar had given refuge to embattled rulers, he would only ever treat them as vassals. He began to address the sultan as Yusuf Khan, and not by his title, and the balance of power was forever altered. After regaining power, Yusuf Shah further alienated the Kashmiri people by exacting violent revenge upon his opponents, including gouging out their eyes, and exasperated his own supporters by ‘excessive indulgence in merry making and gross neglect of state affairs’. Internal dissensions, volatility and rivalries, long a trait of rulers in this region, now became widespread. Haidar Chak, a rival warlord, rode over to Lahore and joined the imperial service under Governor Man Singh. From now on, defectors and soldiers would supply the Mughals with local intelligence as well as invaluable local guides and fighters.

If the year 1580 saw Akbar concerned with the furthest eastern frontiers of his kingdom, then he was simultaneously occupied with his western frontier and the teal-green seas off Surat and further away still with the firangi menace that was Portugal. Early in the year, Akbar sent a party with an uncle of Mirza Aziz Koka ‘to capture the European ports’ with orders ‘to remove the firangis who were a stumbling block in the way of the pilgrims